



The keeper of lost art

Former England wicketkeeper Jack Russell on painting, Rishabh Pant, and why cricket is **losing the craft** of glovework.

Shayan Acharya
shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in

Jack Russell is a busy man. In one of the posh lanes of central London, he pursues his passion — painting portraits — a profession he's embraced for more than three decades. The former England wicketkeeper is now an acclaimed artist and runs a premier art gallery. When in London, he makes it a point to be at the Chris Beetles Gallery, where his cricket-themed artworks evoke nostalgia.

At 61, Russell travels around the country, capturing landscapes on canvas. He avoids mobile phones, preferring email for communication.

Yet, even amid brushes and canvases, cricket remains close to his heart. Whenever the topic comes up, you can see the glint in his eyes.

"I still love cricket. But it's just that painting is the only skill I can do now because I can't play anymore. I've been a professional artist longer than I was a cricketer. So, that's how I've ended up earning more money because I've done it for a longer period of time," he tells *Sportstar* with a smile.

Russell is impressed with Rishabh Pant's grit, batting through a broken foot in Manchester. Yet, such batting heroics cannot hide a wider concern — that the art of wicketkeeping is on the decline, with players focusing more on run-scoring than refining

their glovework.

"It has been like this for a while. It's just the norm now. They look at batters first, and wicketkeeping is secondary. So, that's just what all the teams are doing now. That's just the way it is," he says.

During his playing days, Russell was replaced by Alec Stewart, as selectors preferred a stronger batter who could also keep wickets. Despite featuring in 54 Tests and 40 ODIs, Russell eventually faded from the international scene.

He believes this tradition continues. "But that's fraught with danger because mistakes are often made. They think it's a shortcut, but as a wicketkeeper, you have got to be so careful. If you miss skill, then